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CONVERSION OR COMPULSION

SIXTEEN years ago Gandhiji impressed India with his doctrine of non-violence. Ever since then it has dominated the Indian horizon. Vast numbers of people have repeated it unthinkingly but with approval, some have wrestled with it and then accepted it, with or without reservation, some have openly jeered at it. It has played a major part in our political and social life, and it has also attracted a great deal of attention in the wider world. The doctrine is of course almost as old as human thought, but perhaps Gandhiji was the first to apply it on a mass scale to political and social movements. Formerly it was an individual affair and was thus essentially religious. It was the restraint of the individual and his attempt to achieve complete disinterestedness and thus to raise himself above the level of worldly conflict and attain a kind of personal freedom and salvation. There was no idea behind it of dealing with the larger social problems and of changing social conditions, except very indirectly and remotely. There was almost an acceptance of the existing social fabric with all its inequality and injustice. Gandhiji tried to make this individual ideal into a social group ideal. He was out to change political conditions as well as social; and deliberately, with this end in view, he applied the non-violent method on this wider and wholly different plane. "Those who have to bring about radical changes in human conditions and surroundings," he has written, "cannot do it except by raising a ferment in society. There are only two methods of doing this, violent and non-violent. Violent pressure is felt on the physical being and it degrades him who uses it as it depresses the victim, but non-violent pressure exerted through self-suffering, as by fasting, works in an entirely different way. It touches not the phyiscal body but it touches and strengthens the moral fibre of those against whom it is directed." [1]

The idea was to some extent in harmony with Indian thought and it was accepted, superficially at least, with enthusiasm by the country. Very few realised the far-reaching implications that lay behind it, and the few who did so rather vaguely took refuge in faith and action. But, when the tempo of action

[1] Extracts from statement made by Gandhiji on December 4, 1932 on the occasion of one of his fasts.